

Coral reef

Tropical coral reefs are the most complex of all underwater habitats. They are created by simple animals called corals that live in big colonies and have hard, stony skeletons. The coral colonies shelter an amazing variety of marine life, including many kinds of fish and invertebrates.

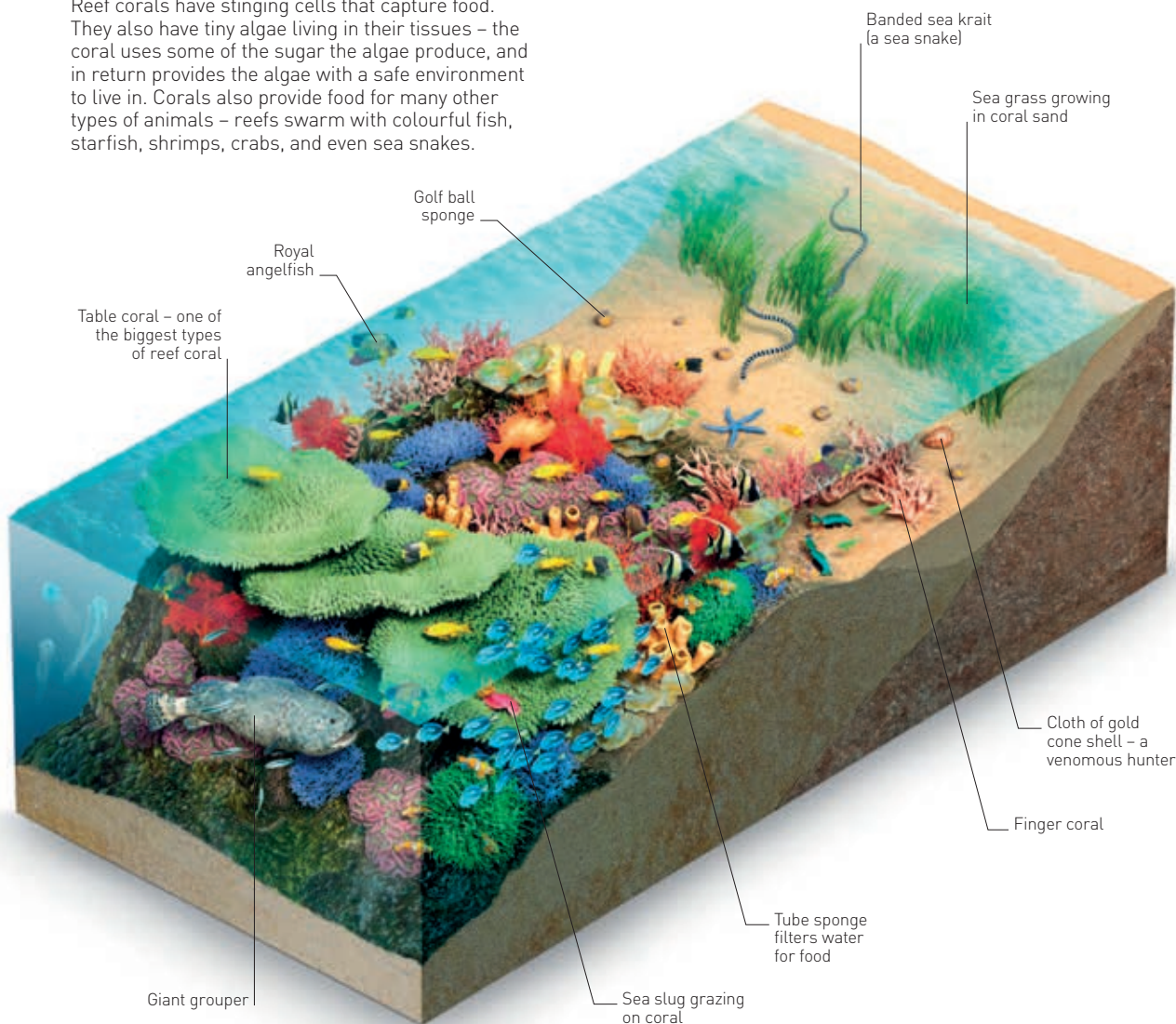
WHERE IN THE WORLD?

Coral reefs grow in clear, shallow, warm water near tropical shores. Most of them lie in the western Pacific and Indian oceans.



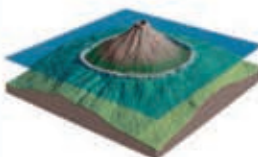
LIFE IN A CORAL REEF

Reef corals have stinging cells that capture food. They also have tiny algae living in their tissues – the coral uses some of the sugar the algae produce, and in return provides the algae with a safe environment to live in. Corals also provide food for many other types of animals – reefs swarm with colourful fish, starfish, shrimps, crabs, and even sea snakes.



TYPES OF REEFS

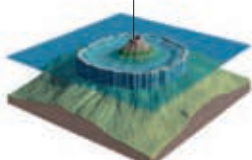
Many reefs grow around islands, forming fringes of coral in the shallow water. If an island is an extinct volcano, it gradually sinks, while the reef keeps growing upwards. This creates a barrier reef. Eventually, the island sinks from sight, leaving a coral atoll.



FRINGING REEF

This tropical volcanic island is surrounded by a fringing reef. The extinct volcano slowly starts to sink.

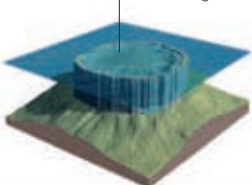
The island sinks, but the coral keeps growing



BARRIER REEF

As the island continues to sink, the reef grows upwards, forming a barrier reef around a ring-shaped lagoon.

Reef encloses a shallow central lagoon

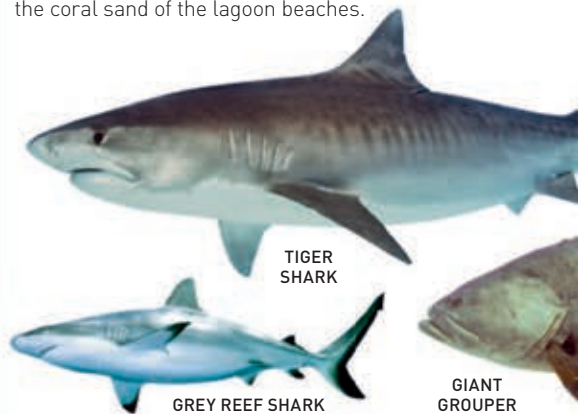


ATOLL

The original island sinks below the waves, leaving behind a ring of coral – an atoll.

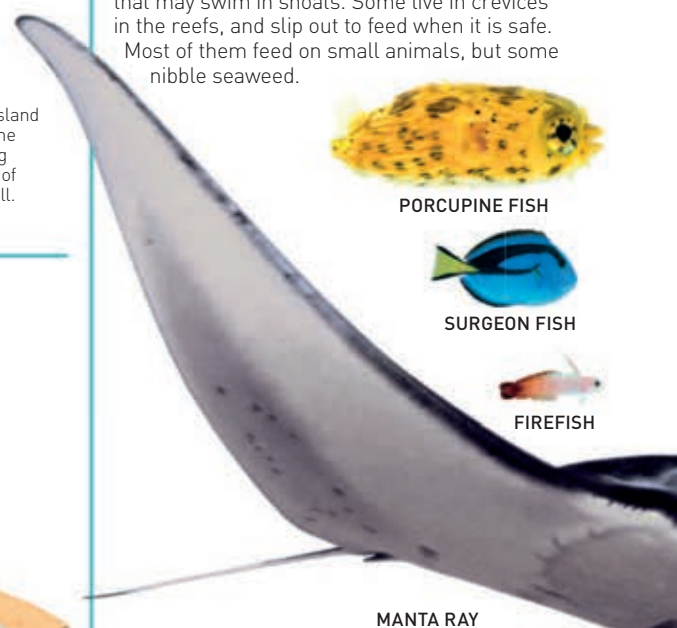
BIG VISITORS

The animals living on the reefs attract big hunters such as giant groupers, sharks, and dolphins. These usually hunt in the deeper channels between the corals. Sea turtles may visit to lay their eggs in the coral sand of the lagoon beaches.



REEF FISH

The water around the coral is alive with small fish that may swim in shoals. Some live in crevices in the reefs, and slip out to feed when it is safe. Most of them feed on small animals, but some nibble seaweed.



REEF INVERTEBRATES

As well as corals, many other invertebrates live on the reefs. Sponges, sea squirts, and clams filter the water for food, while sea slugs, shrimps, and crabs search for scraps and living prey.



CORALS

Every coral reef is made up of many different types of coral. They include brain corals, staghorn corals, and sea fans. Each one is a colony of animals sharing a hard, stony skeleton.

